STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 15 · No North Star

Transcript · Wes Hart

Good to have you here. Sit if you're still sorting your keys. Uh, a man near the door checked the clock, checked his phone, and checked the clock again, as if one of them might take his side. Neither one did. I've lost that vote. Good you came in. If we haven't met, I'm Wes. That's plenty. Last lesson we named a shape a man's days can take. Some of you said yours plain. Some of you, uh, walked around it. In this lesson I want the heading under the days.

Now listen. A lot of us can tell the clock. What time we roll out. What time we have to be back. Ask a man what— ask a man what he is for, and the fog comes up. I mean, the schedule is sharp. The aim is smoke. He can run a whole day on that smoke. I have. Things get done. The list gets checked. He can, uh, tell you he was useful. Ask him the point of it, and he hands you the list again. He still can't say what he was aiming at when he started. Here's the thing. Most of us steer by lights that sit close. A porch light. The glow on the next task. Whatever is lit in your hand. Those lights are real. They help you miss a ditch. They also move when you move. You head toward one, and it slides, because it was never fixed overhead. A north star stays. You turn around, and it's still there. Nearby light will carry a hard afternoon. It cannot tell you which way is north.

That's the trouble. A man can feel sure and be aimed wrong. Uh, the sure part came from a light that was moving with him. So he never, you know, felt the slide. We're gonna name those lights. Then we look at the one that doesn't move.

These marks are the sentence we keep coming back to. I have not improved them. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

You've heard them in this room. I'm not opening all four from the ground up. Here they need a heading, or a man aims them at whatever is glowing. Uh, I can say them clean and still chase the nearest light. I have— I have done that with a steady voice and a crooked aim. Stop waiting. That includes the kind that will not look up from the light in its hand. A man, uh, stays busy. He calls the busy faithful. He never asks where it's pointed. I watched a man live the marks and still not know what they served. He wanted God pleased. Uh, ask him pleased by what, and he named a nearby light. An old rule from his father. A number on a page. The sense that he was behind. The marks were honest. The heading was— the heading was borrowed. That's how a decent man travels a long way off without a scandal to point at. He stayed faithful to a light that had been sliding. Pick up the weight. The heading is yours to name. You don't get to blame the fog if you never looked for north. Go first. Courage aimed at a moving light is just a fast circle. A man can be brave and still take his house the wrong direction. And the pay. God's pay. Not the nod from the closest light.

If the only prize you trust can walk off, you will follow it. The marks are not the heading. They tell a man how to walk. They still need a star that stays.

Let me say what a nearby light is. It is anything close enough to make you feel aimed. Uh, it can be decent. A father can be a good man. A friend can be worth hearing. The talk around you notices real things. A feeling can tell you you're tired. A win can mean the work was actually good. None of that belongs in the trash. The trouble starts when a man makes one of them north. I mean, he quits checking it against anything that holds still. Then the light moves, and he moves with it, and the drift stays hidden, because his mark drifted too. You've, uh, felt the look-up. The place you meant to stand is not the place you're standing. You were careful. You just can't point to the turn. There was no loud moment. It felt sensible the whole way. Picture a county road after dark. Porch lights. The bright lot by the store. Uh, they keep a tire out of the grass. They will not tell you that you turned the wrong way back at the last crossing. You can thank a light and still be headed away from the people you meant to reach. Sensible is what drift wears while it's still moving. A north star is ruder than that. It will not flatter the way you already chose. It just stays. If you will look at it, you can tell you've slid.

Five lights do this to men. A father. Other men. The culture around him. His feelings. His success. You probably have a favorite. I did. How many of you can feel which one, and you'd rather keep it foggy? Hand up. I'm not writing it down. Yeah. Hold it. We'll put a true name on it before you work the page.

For a lot of us the first light was a father. What he praised, that was manhood. What he ignored, a man could skip. Uh, that gets in early. Then you grow, and you find he was aiming too. He had lights of his own. Some, uh, were good. Some moved. If he was hard to find, in the house or out of it, you can steer by the gap. The gap is not a star. It just feels like one, because you keep checking it. Take what was true in him. Don't hang your course on him.

I caught myself a while back. Something came up with one of my kids. A tone I was about to use. Before I asked what was right, I checked a face. My dad's. Not the real one on the phone. The one I keep for a quick grade. I stood there with the words ready. My kid was waiting to learn which man he was about to get. And I was polling somebody who was not in the house. You know, the small version hides better. A purchase. A short tone with my wife. A yes I gave too fast at work. First listener was his face. Not because he asked for the seat. Because I had set him as north. I was not— I was not asking God. I was asking if the old man would nod. I love him. He has also been wrong about things. I hung a choice on a nod he was not in the room to give. That was unfair to him. It was worse for my kid. Uh, a father's praise is a gift. It is a bad north star. If the hurt is what you've been using, hear me kind. The hurt is real. The hurt is not north.

You can honor the man and still take him off the heading. A son can love a father without orbiting him.

Other men are the next light. Uh, this one feels sharp, because you can see them. You can feel where you rank, right? At least you think you can. I kept— I kept a quiet score with a man I worked near. He never agreed to play. If I was ahead in my own head, I went home feeling like a man. If he got the nod and I didn't, I spent the ride rewriting the day. I mean, same hours. New grade. His day, not mine. I was losing a contest he had not entered. He would have been confused. He thought we were fine. We were fine. I was the one holding a bent stick and calling it a ruler. Some of you did that with a man already in this room. You sized him up before you sat. I mean, not out loud. Behind him, you feel small. Ahead of him, you feel free to coast. He did not volunteer. Uh, a church will offer another. The man who talks easy. The man whose house looks lined up. You borrow him as the measure and never ask

if he is true. A fine-looking man can still be off. You don't need his life. You need a mark that isn't a man. Here's what that stick can't do. Two men can both be off. The one who is less off is still off. You can come out ahead of every man you see and still be aimed at the wrong thing. Uh, a comparison will let you feel clean without ever looking up. Take him off the heading. Not his name. His job as your star. You were not built to circle him. He was not built to hold still for you. So ask a harder thing. Not, am I ahead of him. What am I actually measuring, on a day nobody hands out nods?

Culture is a light somebody can swap. Uh, what a room of men rewards does not stay put. The sign in front of a store gets changed. For a while it tells a man to be hard. Later it tells him the hard was the problem. Noticing is allowed. You are in a ditch if you borrow your manhood from the sign. They will change it. You will rebuild. And you will call the rebuild growth, when you only grabbed a newer light. I have sat at a table of men while everybody nodded. The nod felt like north, because nobody pushed back. Uh, a room that agrees is not north. It is a row of nearby lights wearing one color. Feelings step up next. They sound holy if you give them the mic. Something in me is against this, so it must be wisdom. I feel it strong, so it must be the Lord. Sometimes it is. Sometimes you are wrung out, or sore, or still hot from a sentence at lunch. Give me a hard afternoon and a quiet house after, and I can feel a ruling I would not sign at breakfast. The ruling sounds deep. It is just late. I came in once with the day still on my shoulders. By the time the house went quiet, I had— I had a full verdict. The whole life was off. I was sure. I slept. Morning would not sign it. The verdict would not stand. I had nearly steered by it. Uh, I have called a mood a leading. The mood had a lot of confidence. A feeling can report the wind. It cannot choose the road. I mean, it spins when the day spins. Steer by it, and you will name the spin discernment. It isn't. It's weather. And weather is a nearby light with a serious voice.

Success says if it worked, it was right. The bill, uh, got paid. The problem got handled. Nobody sent a complaint. So the man must be sound. Uh, that is a receipt. A receipt proves you paid. It does not prove you bought the right thing. I had a run where the work showed. People could, you know, see it. I carried that into the evening the way a man carries a passing grade. My boy was out front. He had a small thing to show me. Nothing that would impress a stranger. He wanted, uh, a man to look. He'd been out there a while. I saw it when I got close. The thing was in his hands. I don't even remember what it was. I remember the wave, because it cost me nothing and I counted it— I counted it as showing up. Uh, a wave is not presence from a man already inside his own story. He went around the side before I reached the good part. That walk should have graded the day. The win graded it instead. He did not need the story. He needed the front yard. The win had already smiled on me. The yard had not. I let the smile be the measure. I have done smaller copies of that more times than I want said back to me. A thing people can see goes right, and I let it cover the hidden thing I skipped. You can be trusted on the job and missing where it counts, and the job will not turn you in. Success likes you. It will walk a long way beside a wrong aim and keep saying you're fine.

If the days look strong and the people closest to you have gone quiet, don't ask the win. The win is a fan. A fan is not a star.

There is a word that does not move when you do. Not your father's. Not the room's. God's. Proverbs twenty-nine, verse eighteen. Where there is no revelation, people cast off restraint; but blessed is the one who heeds wisdom's instruction.

Stay on that opening. Where there is no revelation. No word, uh, from outside you. Then the lines come off. A man does what seems workable in the hour he is standing in. He calls it, you know, freedom. It is a life with the heading torn off. Restraint is not a mood you work up. It is a man who keeps the lines on when a nearer light says he may drop them. Uh, the blessing in that verse is not a rush of clarity. It is a man who hears and actually heeds. Uh, revelation here is God saying what is true while your lights argue. Blessed is the man who heeds it. He pays attention to a word he did not write. The prophets already said how long it holds. Isaiah forty, verse eight. The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God endures forever.

Grass goes. Flowers go. The big scenery, uh, goes. His word stays. A mood, uh, passes. A good run at work passes. A whole crowd's opinion passes. That word does not pass.

You don't have to— you don't have to understand why a thing does not move to be saved by it.

I can't explain a star. I can set a course by one. You can fuss at a mile marker because you wish the road bent. The marker will not bend. That is how it keeps you from handing away ground you did not mean to hand away. God's Word is that kind of fixed. It will not take a vote from the light you like best.

So what does a man do. You are not drawing a whole map in this lesson. Uh, I have tried to draw the map first. I wanted the place, the work, the years ahead, all of it clear, before I would take one step. That felt serious. It was waiting with a notebook. Here's the practice. Open Mark. One stretch. Out loud, if you can stand your own voice. One question— one question while you read. What does this say a man does? Write the answer in one line. Then do the thing the line named. Not the whole route. The next step you can actually take. Some men leave it shut because nobody showed them. They opened it, got lost, and decided it belonged to a smarter room. That is a gap in practice. It is not a stamp on you. Start with Mark. Stay until you can see the Man you say you follow. Some of you want a feeling before you'll trust it. I have shut it because I felt nothing, and the nothing felt like failure. I have stared at one blank line as if it had insulted my whole education. The line was fine. I wanted a thrill. Uh, the word is not there to thrill you. It is there to tell the truth while your feelings are still spinning. And some of you will say the day has no room. A man who finds room for every nearby light, and no room for the one thing that holds still, has already picked his star. He just has not said the name. I mean, the calendar already confessed. Uh, don't wait until you feel ready. You can do it quietly, before the day starts handing out stars. Write the line where your own eyes will hit it. One stretch. One question. One line. Then do it. Enough for the next honest step.

Let me tell you about a man named Carl. I have known him a long time. Good hands. Bills paid. If a thing broke, he was already walking toward it. People, uh, trusted him with the hard jobs. Uh, his wife had mostly quit bringing him the heavy sentences. She would start. "We're fine" was already loaded. He did not mean to close her out. Fine felt, you know, honest, because nothing in the work was burning. His boy asked him to come see something he'd made. Small. The boy was proud of it anyway. That morning a problem showed up. Other men could have taken it. Carl, uh, went. In the light he was using, a man who is needed is a man. He sent a text. Start without me. One word came back. Ok. He told it to me later the way you tell a knot in the schedule. Two good things, he said. I asked what he used to grade the day. The problem got handled, he said, and his name stayed clean. I asked what the boy used. Carl went quiet. We opened Mark right there. He read it slow, out loud. Mark one, verse

thirty-five. Very early in the morning, while it was still dark, Jesus got up, left the house and went off to a solitary place, where he prayed. Carl wrote on the back of an envelope. A man meets God before he runs toward whoever is calling. He did that the next morning. He said, uh, it felt flat. Then he found his boy, who had already put the thing away, and he asked to see it anyway. The boy got it out of a closet. Four minutes. Carl told me those four minutes had been waiting on him longer than the problem ever waited. The job never said he was off. The verse did. Then the boy did.

Let me walk this room. If you're young, don't wait on a finished plan. Uh, I knew a young man named Eddie. Out on his own. He would not open Mark until the whole route was drawn. The work. The town. A woman he had not met. He called the waiting wisdom. It was a nearby light with the name someday. One morning he read a stretch and wrote, a man follows. He still had no town picked. He had a step. He took it. If you're single, Hear this plain. A wife you hope for is not the star. She would be, uh, a poor north. She is a person. She moves, and she is allowed to move. Your life has a heading before she has a name. If you're married, she is not the measure either. Love her. Don't make her hold north for the house. I have— I have set her there, then felt cheated when she could not be God. If the house is tired, a late feeling will offer to judge the whole marriage. Don't let it write the ruling. Read first. Then talk to her. If the marriage came apart, some other man's life will try to grade you. His peace. His, uh, new start. That grade moves. Your Father is not using that man's score on you. If you're hurt, the wound is not north. Don't steer by the pain and give the pain a holy name. If you've been around a long time, years of nearby lights are, uh, still fog. The years did not freeze them. And if the job is going well, a strong run is not a heading. A crowded calendar isn't either. You can be booked from morning on and still aimed nowhere that stays. Uh, full will swear it is north. It is only full. Be grateful for a good run. Then look higher than the run.

Let me say the whole thing plain, and then I'll get out of the way. A man can know the clock and still have no north. Nearby lights are real. They move. A father. Other men. The culture. Feelings. Success. Any one of them will steer you and hide the drift, because it drifts along with you. God's Word does not drift. You don't have to understand why it holds still to be saved by it.

I hope you— I hope you leave able to name the light you have actually been using. Not the one you respect from far off. The one that has been grading your days. Your workbook has the room for it. In a minute you, uh, sit at the tables and work this part together. So put the questions in your ear the way you will say them. What have you actually been measuring your life against this year? Father, other men, culture, feelings, or success. A full sentence. Out loud. Here. Where did that moving star pull you lately? Name the pull. A real place it took you. And will you open Mark as you go and write one line? One stretch. What it says a man does. Then you do it. Uh, tell a brother the star you named. Read him one verse from what you read. Tell him what it said a man does, and whether you did it. If all you tell him is that you've been busy, he can, you know, nod, and you stay in the fog. How many of you already know the light, and want to keep the sentence soft? Hand up. Nobody is collecting them. Alright. Don't drop it on the walk to the table. You've carried the marks through this room. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

Name the star. Open Mark. Take the step. Tables. Work that part of the workbook together. Start, uh, with what you've been measuring. Say it plain.